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Having beaten Australia 2–0 at home in October–November 2008, we were optimistic about the home series against England in December. Gary Kirsten, our coach, had instilled a sense of confidence in the players and all we needed to do now was sustain the momentum after the retirements of Anil and Sourav, two of the best players to represent India.

England in India, December 2008

England's tour started with a seven-match series of ODIs. I did not play in the first three because I was suffering from another elbow problem, this time what is known as a 'golfer's elbow'. It troubled me throughout the season, but not enough to miss a Test match, and it actually turned out to be one of the best seasons of my career. My good form extended into the next season, and I was nominated the ICC's Cricketer of the Year for 2009–10.

After making only 11 in my comeback match in Bangalore, I was more satisfied with a fifty in the fifth game at Cuttack on 26 November, which we won comfortably, taking a 5–0 series lead. Shortly after the game we heard that some sort of gang war had started in Mumbai. We were deeply perturbed by what we saw on the news channels in the dressing room. It was obviously much more than a gang war and the live footage left us shocked. Our thoughts and prayers went out to the people who were caught up in the catastrophe.

Most of the players watched what was happening on television till late into the night and it became clear to us that India was essentially under